

THE HOSPITAL BAG CHECKLIST

Everything to pack. Nothing you don't need.

Three bags, done right, so nobody's sending you back to the car at 2am. What she needs, what the baby needs, and what your actual job is once you're in that room.

BEFORE YOU PACK

Pack three bags, not one.

One bag becomes a scavenger hunt at 3am. Split it into hers, baby's, and yours — pack them separately, and stage them by the door (or the trunk) by 36 weeks. Most of what's below you already own. This isn't a shopping list — it's a "did you actually put it in the bag" list.

For Her

Comfort and recovery first — the hospital supplies more than you think, this fills the gaps.

- ☐ **ID, insurance card, hospital paperwork** — the one bag nobody can forget.
- ☐ **Phone charger** — the long one, plus a portable battery.
- ☐ **Going-home outfit** — loose, comfortable, not pre-pregnancy size.
- ☐ **Nursing bra + nursing-friendly top**, even if breastfeeding plans aren't final.
- ☐ **Her own pillow** — a distinct pillowcase so it doesn't get lost in hospital linens.
- ☐ **Flip-flops or slides** for the shower and walking the halls.
- ☐ **Toiletries** — toothbrush, deodorant, hair tie, lip balm, contacts/glasses.
- ☐ **Her own maxi pads** — heavy-flow, postpartum-specific, ideally already tested.
- ☐ **Snacks she actually likes** — labor and recovery both run long.
- ☐ **A robe or button-up nightgown** — easier for skin-to-skin and nursing than pajama sets.

For Baby

The hospital provides the basics for the stay — this is what goes home.

- ☐ **Car seat, installed and inspected** — no leaving without it, most hospitals check.
- ☐ **Going-home outfit** — season-appropriate, one size up from newborn if born early.
- ☐ **A swaddle blanket** for the car seat ride home.
- ☐ **A hat** — hospitals run cold, newborns lose heat fast.
- ☐ **Burp cloths** — two or three, more than you think you need.

For You

You're staying too — pack like it, not like you're running out for coffee.

- ☐ **A change of clothes** — labor and delivery run longer than anyone plans for.
- ☐ **Phone charger + portable battery** — you'll be the one taking every photo and sending every update.
- ☐ **Cash, small bills** — vending machines and hospital cafeterias aren't always card-friendly.
- ☐ **Toiletries + deodorant** — you may not shower for a day or two, but you can still not smell like it.
- ☐ **A pillow and a layer** — the pull-out chair/couch is not built for sleep, and rooms run cold at night.
- ☐ **Snacks and a real water bottle** — you are support staff, and support staff needs fuel.
- ☐ **Headphones** — for the moments you need five minutes that are just yours.
- ☐ **A list of who to call** — and who *not* to call until you're ready. Decide this before you're in the room.

Documents & Logistics

The unglamorous stuff that actually holds things up if it's missing.

- ☐ **Photo ID and insurance card** — both of you, hospital registration asks for both.
- ☐ **Hospital pre-registration paperwork**, if your hospital does it in advance — do it in advance.
- ☐ **Birth plan copies** — printed, not just on a phone. One for the nurse, one for the binder.
- ☐ **Pediatrician's name and info** — you'll be asked before you leave.
- ☐ **Car seat manual** or a YouTube link saved offline — install it before you need it, not in the parking lot.
- ☐ **A folder for discharge paperwork** — you'll leave with more paper than you expect.

Stage the bags by 36 weeks. Full term is 37–40 weeks, but plenty of healthy babies show up earlier. By the door, by the car seat, or already in the trunk — the goal is zero last-minute packing while contractions are happening.

Your Actual Job in That Room

The bag is the easy part. This is the part nobody hands you a checklist for.

- ☐ **Be the calm one.** She reads your face before she reads the monitor. Steady, not silent.
- ☐ **Be the advocate.** Ask the questions she doesn't have bandwidth to ask. Speak up if something feels off.
- ☐ **Run the room.** Visitors, phone calls, the door — that's your job so it's never hers.
- ☐ **Document it, don't perform it.** A few real photos beat a highlight reel. Put the phone down for the parts that matter.

Whatever's actually happening in that room — a fast, easy delivery or a plan that falls apart in ninety seconds — that's what **the Dudela Prep Kit** walks through hour by hour: six pillars, nine printable tools, real founder stories from a NICU stay and an emergency C-section.

Real Talk from John & Mike

Neither of our hospital bags mattered as much as we thought they would. John's twins arrived early and spent a month in the NICU — the bag sat packed for weeks before it was ever used. Mike's fully-mapped birth plan fell apart into an emergency C-section in about ninety seconds, and none of it went the way the checklist implied it would. Pack the bag. Then hold it loosely — your actual job is showing up steady for whatever the room actually needs, not the version you planned for.

— John & Mike, Dudela

This checklist is general guidance, not medical advice. Follow your hospital's specific pre-registration and packing guidance, and your own OB or midwife's instructions, over anything written here.